

Japanese, Step by Step, Sign by Sign

A gentle introduction to contemporary standard Japanese,
one sign and one word at a time

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Starter edition — eight short lessons in one cumulative chapter.

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How to use this starter edition

Begin with no assumed Japanese. Each section takes one small expression, teaches only the writing that expression needs, explains where the word came from, and ends with a short retrieval prompt. There is no kana chart to memorise first.

Japanese uses three writing systems at the same time, and an ordinary sentence contains all three. *Hiragana* carries the grammar, *kanji* carry the content words, and *katakana* marks words borrowed from outside. This edition therefore opens all three in its first chapter rather than finishing one before starting the next, because no real sentence waits for you to.

Two habits are worth forming immediately. First, count beats. Every written kana is one beat of equal length, and length changes meaning: いえ is a house, いいえ is “no”. Second, expect a kanji to have several readings. The character 日 is read *nichi*, *jitsu*, *hi*, *bi*, or *ka* depending on the word it stands in, so this book always teaches the reading a word uses rather than pretending a character has one sound.

Romanization stands beside the Japanese here and will fade in later editions. Where a lesson is teaching beat count it also spells a word out beat by beat, because the macron in *arigatō* hides exactly what is being taught.

A note on what this book does not claim. Japanese shares no ancestor with English, so there is no family of English cousin words to hang new vocabulary on — and none is invented here. What Japanese does have is a real borrowed layer from Chinese, shared with Mandarin and Korean, an internal etymology of its own, and a handful of genuine loans from Portuguese, Dutch, German, and English. Those are used. Nothing else is.

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Chapter 1

Three Writing Systems in One Doorway

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) 👁 eyes (7) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 8 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone in the daytime, answer yes or no, and thank them politely, reading each word in the script Japanese actually uses for it.

A six-line daytime doorway exchange that mixes hiragana and kanji and uses no untaught word.

1.1 はい — yes, in two equal beats

Nothing is assumed yet. Begin with the shortest useful answer in the language, and with the first of its three writing systems.

Script — two signs, two beats

はい — は *ha* + い *i*

Japanese runs left to right. はい is written with two signs of **hiragana**, the everyday script. A hiragana sign is not a letter. It is one whole beat — a **mora** — and normally a consonant and a vowel already fused into one shape. There is no separate *h* to write, because は already is *ha*.

Five vowels, and they stay pure: *a* as in father, *i* as in machine, then *u*, *e*, *o*. So はい is *ha-i*, two beats of the same length, and not the single gliding sound of English “high.”

The word, taken apart

はい means **yes**, and also “here you are,” “I am listening,” and “present.” Its origin is genuinely unsettled: some accounts tie it to 拝 *hai*, “a bow”; others treat it as an old interjection. Neither is proven, so hold it as an open question rather than a fact.

Say plainly what is true here. Japanese shares no ancestor with English, so no cousin word is waiting in your vocabulary to hold はい in place. What this track offers instead is the writing itself, built up one sign at a time, and — later — the real family Japanese does have, through the characters it borrowed.

Your turn

- *Say it:* はい — *ha-i*, two even beats] [REPEAT x2
- *Read it:* は, then い, left to right
- *Answer:* your name is called → はい

Before you move on

How many beats does はい hold? (Two.) Which sign carries *ha*? (は.)

Source: Wiktionary: はい.

1.2 いいえ — no, and why the extra beat matters

Say はい once and count its two beats out loud. This lesson adds the opposite answer, and one fact about beats that Japanese will never let go of.

Script — one new sign, three beats

いいえ — い *i* + い *i* + え *e*

Only え *e* is new; い you already read in はい. Written out, the word is three signs, so it is three beats: *i-i-e*. The first two are the same sign twice, which is exactly how Japanese writes a long vowel in hiragana — by writing the vowel again.

Beat count is not decoration. いえ (two beats) means **house**. いいえ (three beats) means **no**. Nothing else distinguishes them. Hold the first *i* for two beats and the word lands; clip it and you have said “house.”

The word, taken apart

いいえ is the plain **no** — and, just as often, a modest “**not at all**” used to wave away thanks or a compliment. That second use is the common one in daily speech, which is worth knowing before you meet it as an answer to **thank you** at the end of this chapter.

Your turn

- *Say it:* いいえ — *i-i-e*, three even beats] [REPEAT x2
- *Contrast:* いえ house, いいえ no
- *Choose:* agree → はい; decline → いいえ

Before you move on

Which single sign is new here? (え.) What changes when the long *i* is cut short? (The word becomes いえ, house.)
Source: Wiktionary: いいえ.

1.3 こんにちは — hello, and a sign that lies about its sound

Retrieve はい and the sign は. You are about to meet は again in the daytime greeting — where it is not pronounced *ha*.

Script — four new signs, and one you know

こんにちは — こ *ko* + ん *n* + に *ni* + ち *chi* + は

Four signs are new. こ *ko*, に *ni*, and ち *chi* behave like every hiragana so far: one sign, one consonant-plus-vowel beat.

ん is the exception worth naming. It is the one hiragana that is a bare consonant, and it still takes a full beat of its own. So こんにちは is five signs and five beats: *ko-n-ni-chi-wa*. Give ん its own beat and the greeting sounds Japanese; swallow it and it does not.

Grammar Lens — the sign は, read *wa*

The last sign is は, which you learned as *ha*. Here it is read **wa**. That is not an exception to memorize blindly. は is Japanese's **topic particle** — the little word that marks what a sentence is about, roughly “as for ____.” Japanese spelling was reformed in 1946 to follow pronunciation, but three grammatical particles were left at their older spellings because they are so frequent that respelling them would have rewritten every page in the country. は is one of them. Rule to carry forward: は is *ha* inside a word, and *wa* when it is doing the job of a particle.

Why it's said this way

こんにちは is the daytime greeting — roughly midday to dusk, not morning and not evening. It is a sentence that was abandoned halfway. In full it was 今日は... *konnichi wa*..., “as for today ...”, opening a longer enquiry after someone's health. The rest fell away and the topic marker stayed, which is why Japan's most common greeting ends on a grammatical particle instead of a word. Those two characters, 今日 *konnichi* “this day,” belong to the third writing system, and the next lesson opens it.

Your turn

- *Say it:* こんにちは — *ko-n-ni-chi-wa*, five beats] [REPEAT x2
- *Decide:* は in はい → *ha*; は ending the greeting → *wa*
- *Greet:* someone at midday → こんにちは

Before you move on

Which sign takes a beat without a vowel? (ん.) Why does the greeting end in a particle? (It is the opening of a sentence nobody finishes any more.)

Source: Wiktionary: こんにちは.

1.4 日本語 — three characters, and no single sound each

Say こんにちは. Its history hid two characters, 今日, that hiragana cannot show you. This lesson opens that second system by naming the language itself.

Script — kanji, and the readings problem

日本語 — *ni + hon + go*

These are **kanji**: characters borrowed from Chinese, each carrying a meaning rather than a sound. 日 is sun or day. 本 is origin or root. 語 is language. So 日本 is “sun-origin” — the country the sun rises from — and 日本語 is its language.

Now the fact that makes kanji unlike any letter you have learned. A kanji does not have a sound. 日 is read *nichi*, *jitsu*, *hi*, *bi*, or *ka*, depending on the word it stands in — and in 日本 it is shortened again, to *ni*. There is no sensible way to teach “the sound of 日.” What a lesson can teach is the **word**: you learn 日本語 as *nihongo*, and the reading of each character comes along with it.

Two families of readings explain the spread. The **on** reading is Japan’s version of the Chinese pronunciation, imported with the character. The **kun** reading is a native Japanese word written with a borrowed character that already meant the same thing. 日本語 is on-readings throughout; 今日 in the greeting is irregular even by those standards.

The word, taken apart

Here the cousin web finally works — just not toward English. The on-readings *nichi*, *hon*, *go* are borrowings of Middle Chinese, so 日本語 has genuine relatives: Mandarin writes the same three characters and says *Rìběnyǔ*; Korean borrowed the same compound as *ilbon-eo*. Same characters, related imported sounds, one meaning, three languages. That is a real, checkable connection, and it is the honest replacement for the Latin roots that anchor a European language. English has no share in it.

Your turn

- Say it: 日本語 — *ni-ho-n-go*, four beats] [REPEAT x2

- *Name:* 日 sun or day; 本 origin; 語 language
- *Connect:* Mandarin *Rìběnyǔ*, Korean *ilbon-eo*, same three characters

Before you move on

What does 日本 mean literally? (Sun-origin.) Does 日 have one pronunciation? (No — the word it appears in chooses one.)
Source: Wiktionary: 日本語.

1.5 コーヒー — the third system, and a word that really is a cousin

Recall how hiragana writes a long vowel: it writes the vowel twice, as in いいえ. Katakana does it differently, and this word shows how.

Script — katakana, the borrowed-word script

コーヒー — コ *ko* + — + ヒ *hi* + —

This is **katakana**, the third system, and it is a full twin of hiragana: the same beats, the same five vowels, different shapes. Its job is different too. Katakana marks a word as coming from outside — borrowed vocabulary, foreign names, sound effects, scientific terms.

The two scripts are siblings by origin as well as by sound. Hiragana came from whole Chinese characters written in flowing cursive; katakana came from *fragments* of characters, shorthand that monks scribbled beside a text to remember how to read it. コ and □ even trace back to the same character, which is why they still look alike.

— is the *chōonpu*, the long-vowel bar. It holds the previous vowel for one more beat, and it belongs to katakana almost exclusively. So コーヒー is four beats: *ko-o-hi-i*.

The word, taken apart

コーヒー is **coffee**, and it entered Japanese from Dutch *koffie* through the Nagasaki trade. Dutch had it from Turkish *kahve*, and Turkish from Arabic *qahwa* — which is exactly where English *coffee* comes from as well.

So this word genuinely is a cousin of one you already own. Notice what kind of cousin: not an inherited relative, but the same borrowed object arriving from the same Arabic source by two different roads. That is the honest shape of most Japanese–English overlap. Other passengers on those roads: パン bread, from Portuguese *pão*, and アルバイト a part-time job, from German *Arbeit*.

Your turn

- Say it: コーヒー — *ko-o-hi-i*, four beats] [REPEAT x2
- Trace it: Arabic *qahwa* → Turkish *kahve* → Dutch *koffie* → コーヒー
- Decide: a borrowed word is written in katakana, not hiragana

Before you move on

Which script signals a borrowed word? (Katakana.) How many beats does コーヒー hold? (Four.)

Source: Wiktionary: コーヒー.

1.6 ありがとう — thanks, from “this hardly ever happens”

Back to hiragana. Five signs are coming, and one small mark that unlocks a whole second row of sounds.

Script — five signs and two small strokes

ありがとう — あ *a* + り *ri* + が *ga* + と *to* + う

あ *a*, り *ri*, と *to* and う *u* are ordinary hiragana. が is the new idea: it is the sign か *ka* with two short strokes added at the top right. That mark is the **dakuten**, and it voices the consonant — the same two strokes turn *ka* into *ga*, *sa* into *za*, *ta* into *da*, *ha* into *ba*. One mark, learned once, doubles how much of the script you can read.

The final う does not sound like *u* here. After と it stretches the *o*, so the word ends *-tō* and holds five beats: *a-ri-ga-to-o*. Hiragana lengthens a vowel by writing another vowel sign, where katakana used the bar ー.

The word, taken apart

Written in kanji, ありがとう is 有り難う: 有る *aru* “to exist” plus 難し *katashi* “difficult.” Its ancestor 有り難し *arigatashi* meant literally “**hard to exist**” — that is, rare. Rare became precious, precious became grateful, and by the Edo period the word had settled into plain thanks. The *k* of *katashi* softened to *g* inside the compound, which is the same voicing the dakuten writes.

So the memory hook is inside the word, not inside English: saying ありがとう is saying *this was not a thing that had to happen*. No English cousin exists, and inventing one would be worse than admitting that.

Your turn

- *Say it:* ありがとう — *a-ri-ga-to-o*, five beats] [REPEAT x2
- *Build:* か plus the dakuten → が
- *Connect:* 有り難し “hard to exist” → rare → precious → thanks

Before you move on

What did 有り難し mean literally? (Hard to exist.) What does the last う do? (It lengthens the *o*.)
Source: Wiktionary: ありがとう.

1.7 ありがとうございます — politeness you cannot leave out

Say ありがとう once and rebuild が from か. This lesson adds the ending that makes it usable with a stranger, a shopkeeper, or a boss.

Script — five more signs, two of them dakuten

ございます — ご *go* + ざ *za* + い *i* + ま *ma* + す *su*

Two of the five are dakuten forms you can already build: ご is こ with the two strokes, and ざ is さ *sa* with them. い you have read since はい. Only ま *ma* and す *su* are genuinely new.

The whole phrase is ten beats — *a-ri-ga-to-o go-za-i-ma-su* — and the final す is normally said with the *u* barely voiced, close to a plain *s*.

Grammar Lens — politeness is grammar here, not word choice

ございます is a verb. It is the polite form of ある *aru*, “to be” — the same verb that sits inside ありがとう. The route runs ある → ござる → ございます, where the ending -ます is the general politeness marker Japanese attaches to verbs.

That is the difference this chapter has to name. In many languages politeness is a choice between two words for “you.” Japanese instead marks it on the **predicate**, and every sentence has one, so every sentence is marked. There is no neutral setting: ありがとう to a friend and ありがとうございます to a stranger are not two styles of the same form, they are two different grammatical levels, and choosing wrongly is heard immediately.

At the far end of the system, the verb itself is replaced. 言う *iu* “to say” becomes おっしゃる when the speaker is honouring someone else and 申す when humbling themselves. Same act, three verbs, chosen by who is doing what to whom. That is **keigo**, and this lesson is only its front door.

Your turn

- *Say it:* ありがとうございます — ten beats, final *su* light] [REPEAT x2
- *Choose:* a close friend → ありがとう; a shop assistant → ありがとうございます
- *Build:* こ → ご, さ → ざ

Before you move on

Which verb hides inside ございます? (ある, “to be.”) Can a Japanese sentence avoid marking politeness? (No — the predicate always carries a level.)

Source: Wiktionary: ございます.

1.8 Practice — one daytime exchange, three scripts

Before reading on, retrieve three answers: the daytime greeting, the short yes, and the short no. Nothing new is added here.

The exchange — every line already learned

A: こんにちは。 — *Konnichiwa*. B: こんにちは。 — *Konnichiwa*. A: 日本語? — *Nihongo?* B: はい。 — *Hai*. A: ありがとうございます。 — *Arigatō gozaimasu*. B: いいえ。 — *Iie*.

Three lines of hiragana, one of kanji, and no word that has not been taught. Japanese lets a bare noun with a rising tone stand as a question, so 日本語 with the voice lifted is a complete and natural way to ask “Japanese, then?” — and はい answers it. B’s closing いいえ is the modest “not at all” that waves thanks away.

A single ordinary Japanese sentence mixes the systems: hiragana carries the grammar, kanji carries the content words, katakana carries the borrowings. That is why this chapter opened all three instead of finishing one.

Your turn

- *Run through:* both voices once with the Japanese, once with romanization only
- *Decide:* which line would change if B were a close friend] [PAUSE 3s
- *Swap:* take B’s part while the other lines are read to you

Before you move on

Run the exchange once from memory. If a line stalls, return to that one lesson rather than rereading the chapter.

Chapter 2

Eight Signs, and Three Words You Can Read

Modes: ✍ pen (10) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 10 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can write eight hiragana signs from memory and read the daytime greeting and both yes-or-no answers by sounding out their signs in order, including the sign that is pronounced wa because it is a topic marker.

The daytime greeting assembled from five signs the reader can each write from memory, introducing nothing new — including the one read wa because it is a topic marker rather than the sign for that sound.

2.1 い — two strokes, one beat

You already know the rule that makes this writing system easy: **one sign, one beat**. Not one letter one sound, and not one sign one word — one sign, one **mora**, the even beat Japanese counts time in.

What you have not had yet is a single sign taught on its own. Here is the first.

Script — the shape

い

Two strokes, both falling, the left one long and the right one short:

1. the **left** stroke — start high, come down, and hook gently to the right at the bottom
2. the **right** stroke — a short downward tick, higher up and clear of the first

It is read **i**, the vowel of English *machine* — short, tight, never the *eye* of English *bite*.

Where the shape came from, and why it does not help you.

Every hiragana sign began as a Chinese character written fast and cursively until it wore smooth. But those characters were chosen **for their sound**, not their meaning, so unlike a Chinese component there is nothing inside い to decode. The shape is a signature you learn, not a structure you read. This book will tell you when a shape carries information and when it does not, and this is the second kind.

Your turn

- *Write it:* い — long stroke first, then the short tick
- *Say it:* **i**, one clean beat

Before you move on

How many beats does one hiragana sign take? (**One.**)

Source: Unicode Hiragana chart; stroke order per *Hitsujun Shido no Tebiki* (Japanese Ministry of Education, 1958).

2.2 は — three strokes

Write the two-stroke sign you met a moment ago. Long stroke, short tick.

Script — the shape

は

Three strokes. Look at it as a tall left post with a loop tied on its right.

1. the **vertical**, down the left side, with the smallest flick left at the foot
2. a **short horizontal** crossing that vertical near the top, on its right
3. the **loop** — down from the right of that crossbar, round to the left, and back up to close

Read **ha**, breathed rather than hard: the *h* of English *hat*, then the open *a* of *father*.

It has a second reading, and you have already used it. Keep that in your pocket for now — this sign is doing two jobs in Japanese, and the second one is what makes the greeting look misspelled to a beginner. It gets its own lesson, after you have met the sign it *sounds* like.

Your turn

- *Write it:* は — vertical, crossbar, loop
- *Say it:* **ha**, one beat, breath not force

Before you move on

Which stroke of は is written first? (The **vertical** on the left.)

Source: Unicode Hiragana chart; stroke order per *Hitsujun Shido no Tebiki* (Japanese Ministry of Education, 1958).

2.3 Two signs, side by side — and a word appears

Both signs are yours. Write them, in this order, and say each beat as you finish it:

はい

Script — no new sign at all

Now write them touching:

は + い → はい

ha then **i**. Two beats, even, neither one stressed. That is the word for **yes**, and it is the one you have been saying since your first minute in this language.

Nothing new was introduced in this lesson. No stroke, no sound, no word. What changed is where the word now lives: you are no longer recalling a shape you were shown, you are **reading** it — assembling it out of two pieces you can write from memory and sound out in order.

That is the whole method for this writing system, and it does not get harder. It gets longer. A word of five signs is five signs you already own, in a row.

Your turn

- *Read it:* はい — sound each sign in turn, do not recall the word whole
- *Write it:* はい — five strokes in total, three then two

Before you move on

How many new strokes did you have to learn in this lesson? (**None.**)
Source: Unicode Hiragana chart.

2.4 え — two strokes, and a second word for free

Read the word for *yes* off the page, sign by sign, out loud.

Script — the shape

え

Two strokes, and the second one does most of the work:

1. a **short tick** at the top, on its own, clear of everything below
2. the **body** — across to the right, back down and left in a flat zigzag, then out to the lower right in one continuous movement

Read **e**, the vowel of English *bed* — short, and never the *ay* of *day*.

What you've built

Three signs are now yours, and they spell more than one word. Put two of them together with the one you just learned:

い + い + え → いいえ

i-i-e. Three beats — and note that the first sign is written **twice**, because Japanese counts two full beats there. That is the word for **no**. You have now read both answers to a yes-or-no question, from the signs up. Neither of them was memorised as a picture.

Your turn

- *Write it:* え — tick first, then the body in one movement

- *Read it:* いいえ — three beats, and do not shorten the doubled sign

Before you move on

Why is the first sign of that word written twice? (Because it is **two beats**, not one held longer.)

Source: Unicode Hiragana chart; stroke order per *Hitsujun Shido no Tebiki* (Japanese Ministry of Education, 1958).

2.5 こ — two strokes, and the greeting begins

The two-stroke sign read *e* — tick, then body. Write it once.

Script — the shape

こ

The simplest sign you have met. Two short horizontal strokes, stacked, the lower one longer and slightly curved:

1. the **upper** stroke, short, curving down a little at its right end
2. the **lower** stroke, wider, sweeping right and lifting slightly

Read **ko**: a clean *k*, then the *o* of English *more* shortened.

Nothing joins them. The gap between the two strokes is part of the shape — close it and you have a different sign.

Your turn

- *Write it:* こ — upper stroke, then the longer lower one, and leave the gap
- *Say it:* **ko**, one beat

Before you move on

Which of the two strokes is longer? (The **lower** one.)

Source: Unicode Hiragana chart; stroke order per *Hitsujun Shido no Tebiki* (Japanese Ministry of Education, 1958).

2.6 くん — one stroke, one beat, no vowel

Two stacked strokes with a gap. Write the sign read *ko*.

Script — the shape, and the exception

ん

One stroke. Start with a small tick down-left, then sweep down, round to the right and up in a single unbroken movement, finishing with a rise.

Now the part that matters more than the shape. Every sign you have met so far is a consonant plus a vowel, or a vowel alone. **This one is a consonant with no vowel at all** — and it still takes a **full beat**, exactly as long as any other sign.

That is why Japanese counts morae rather than syllables, and it is the clearest evidence you will get. An English speaker hears the *n* at the end of a word as a tail on the vowel before it. Japanese does not. It is its own beat, held its own length, and shortening it is one of the most audible foreign-accent tells there is.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ん — one continuous stroke, no lifts
- *Say it:* hold it for a full beat, as long as any other sign takes

Before you move on

If this sign has no vowel, how long is it held? (**A full beat** — the same as every other sign.)

Source: Unicode Hiragana chart; stroke order per *Hitsujun Shido no Tebiki* (Japanese Ministry of Education, 1958).

2.7 に — three strokes, and a shape you half know

Write the three-stroke sign read *ha*. Vertical, crossbar, loop.

Script — the shape

に

Three strokes, and **the first one you have already practised**:

1. the **vertical** down the left, with the same small flick left at the foot as the sign read *ha* 2. a **short horizontal** to its right, upper area 3. a **longer horizontal** below it, sweeping right

Read **ni**: the *n* of *knee*, then the tight *i* you learned first.

This is the first time two signs share a visible part, and it is worth naming, because it is nearly the last. Hiragana is not built from recombining components the way Chinese characters are — these two happen to have worn down to similar left-hand posts, not because they mean or sound anything alike. Treat the resemblance as a **handwriting** convenience, not as a clue. Reading information into it is the mistake this book keeps warning you off.

Your turn

- *Write it*: に — vertical, short bar, long bar
- *Notice*: write it beside は and compare only the left post

Before you move on

Which stroke of this sign comes first? (The **vertical**.)

Source: Unicode Hiragana chart; stroke order per *Hitsujun Shido no Tebiki* (Japanese Ministry of Education, 1958).

2.8 ち — two strokes, four roman letters, one beat

Three strokes: vertical, short bar, long bar. Write the sign read *ni*.

Script — the shape

ち

Two strokes:

1. a **short horizontal** across the top 2. the **body** — down from the middle of that bar, curving left, then round into a full belly to the right and up

Read **chi**: the *ch* of English *cheese*, then the tight *i*.

Count what just happened. One sign. One beat. **Four roman letters** to describe it. The romanization is a pronunciation aid written for people who do not read the script yet — it is not a smaller version of the writing system, and the number of letters in it tells you nothing about the number of beats in the word.

This is the moment the roman spelling starts costing you more than it pays, and it is why the signs are worth the effort.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ち — top bar, then the body in one movement
- *Say it:* **chi**, one beat — as long as any other sign, no longer

Before you move on

Does the number of roman letters tell you how long a sign is held?
(No.)

Source: Unicode Hiragana chart; stroke order per *Hitsujun Shido no Tebiki* (Japanese Ministry of Education, 1958).

2.9 わ — the sign for *wa*, and the trap beside it

Write the three-stroke sign read *ha*: vertical, crossbar, loop.

Script — the shape

わ

Two strokes:

1. the **vertical** on the left, with the small flick at the foot 2. the **body** — a short bar right from the top, then down, round to the left in a loop, and out to the lower right with a curl

Read **wa**: like English *wa* in *wander*, one beat.

What you've built — and the trap

Here is the thing this sign exists in this lesson to protect you from. The daytime greeting **sounds** like it ends in *wa*. **It is not written with this sign.** It ends with the sign read *ha* — the one you learned early and were told was holding a second job.

That second job is grammatical: **は** is also Japanese's topic marker, and **as a topic marker it is pronounced *wa***. The greeting is a frozen fragment of a longer sentence, and it kept the marker's spelling along with the marker's sound.

So the rule you need is not about sound at all:

- **わ** is the sign for the mora *wa* inside ordinary words.
- **は** read as *wa* means you are looking at the topic marker, or at something that used to contain one.

Getting this backwards is the single most common beginner spelling error in Japanese, and it is the reason this book taught you the sign for *wa* **after** you already knew the greeting — so the shape could arrive with its warning attached rather than be quietly assumed.

Your turn

- *Write it:* **わ**, then **は** beside it — two signs, one shared sound, different jobs
- *Decide:* hearing *wa* at the end of the daytime greeting, which sign do you write?

Before you move on

Which of the two is a fact about **grammar** rather than about sound? (The one where **は** is read *wa*.)

Source: Unicode Hiragana chart; stroke order per *Hitsujun Shido no Tebiki* (Japanese Ministry of Education, 1958).

2.10 Five signs in a row — and the greeting is readable

Four signs, one after another, from memory. Say each beat as you finish writing it:

こ ん に ち

Script — the assembly

Add the fifth — the one that is read *wa* because it is a topic marker — and the greeting is on the page:

こ + ん + に + ち + は → こんにちは

ko-n-ni-chi-wa. Five signs, **five beats**, all even. Say it against a steady tap and you will hear that the second beat, the one with no vowel, takes exactly as long as the four around it.

Nothing new was introduced in this lesson. You have not learned a stroke, a sound or a word here. You have read a word you already knew how to say — from five pieces you can each write from memory, in order, including the one that sounds like something other than its name.

What you’ve built

Eight signs, taught one at a time, and with them you can now read three whole words off the page: the greeting, and both answers to a yes-or-no question.

Hiragana has forty-six basic signs. You hold **eight**. The rest arrive the same way, one per lesson, and the words they unlock arrive free — because a word in this script is never more than the signs you already own, in a row.

Your turn

- *Read it:* こんにちは — sound each sign in turn; do not recall it whole
- *Write it:* the greeting, then say it once at speaking pace

Before you move on

How many of the greeting’s five signs were new in this lesson?

(None.)

Source: Unicode Hiragana chart.

Chapter 3

Eight Signs, One Mark, and the Longest Word You Know

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ✍ pen (10) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 11 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can write eight more hiragana from memory, add the dakuten to voice a sign I already know, and read **ありがとうございます** off the page without the romanization.

The ten signs of the polite thank-you named one by one, three of them earlier signs wearing two ticks, and a short exchange in which every character on the page is one the reader can write.

3.1 あ — three strokes, and the thank-you begins

Write **こんにちは** from memory. Five signs, all yours.

You have been saying **ありがとう** since Chapter 1 and reading it from the romanization. This chapter hands you the signs, one at a time, until the word is yours on the page as well as in the mouth.

Script — the shape

あ

Three strokes, and the third is the one that gives beginners trouble:

1. a short **horizontal**, near the top
2. a **vertical** crossing it, leaning slightly left as it falls
3. a **loop** that starts at the upper right, sweeps down

and left across the vertical, curls round at the bottom, and finishes pointing right

The loop is one continuous movement, not a circle drawn separately. Start it, cross what you have already written, and come back out.

Read **a**: the *a* of English *father*, kept short. One beat.

Your turn

- *Write it*: あ — horizontal, vertical, then the loop in one movement
- *Say it*: **a**, one beat, short

Before you move on

Is the loop drawn as a separate circle, or in one movement? (**One movement**, crossing what you have already written.)

Source: Unicode Hiragana chart

3.2 り — two strokes, and a tap rather than an r

Write あ. Horizontal, vertical, loop.

Script — the shape

り

Two strokes, drawn left to right, and they never touch:

1. a **short left stroke**, curving gently down and to the right 2. a **long right descender**, starting higher, falling much further, and hooking left at the very bottom

The gap between them is the shape. So is the difference in length — the right stroke should fall roughly twice as far as the left.

Now the sound, and it is worth a moment. **Japanese r is not the English r.** It is a single **tap** of the tongue against the ridge behind the teeth — very close to the *r* of Spanish *pero*, and not far from the *dd* in an American saying *ladder*. Your tongue touches once and releases.

If you say an English *r* here you will be understood and you will sound foreign in a way that one minute of practice fixes.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ㇿ — short left stroke, then the long right descender. Leave the gap.
- *Say it:* **ri** — one tap, not an English r
- *Say it:* **a**, then **ri** — the first two signs of the word

Before you move on

Which of ㇿ's two strokes falls further? (The **right** one, by about double.)

Source: Unicode Hiragana chart

3.3 か — three strokes, and a shape you will reuse

Write ㇿ. Short left, long right, gap between.

Script — the shape

か

Three strokes:

1. a **hooked left stroke** — down, curving right at the foot into a small hook
2. a **short vertical**, crossing the first stroke near its top and falling to the right of it
3. a **short dot**, up at the right, slanting down-right

Read **ka**: a clean *k*, then the short *a* of あ. One beat.

Remember this shape more carefully than the others. **You are about to get a second sign out of it for free** — か is the base of が, and the difference between them is two small marks rather than a new character to learn.

Your turn

- *Write it:* か — hooked stroke, vertical, then the dot at the right
- *Say it:* **ka**, one beat

Before you move on

Which stroke is written last? (The **dot**, at the upper right.)
Source: Unicode Hiragana chart

3.4 ` — two ticks, and every sign you know doubles

Write か. Then write こ, from Chapter 2.

Script — the mark

Here is the best bargain in the Japanese writing system.

Two short strokes, slanting down-right, written at the **upper right** of a sign:

`

It is called the **dakuten**, and it does one job: it **voices** the consonant. Voicing is what separates English *k* from *g*, or *s* from *z* — the same mouth position, with the vocal cords switched on.

So:

か *ka* → が *ga*

>

こ *ko* → ご *go*

No new shape. The sign underneath is exactly the one you already write; the marks sit above and to the right of it, small, and clear of the strokes.

This is worth pausing on, because it changes the size of the job in front of you. Hiragana has forty-six signs. Learning the dakuten does not add signs — it **doubles the ones you already have**, at the price of two ticks. Every *k* you know becomes a *g*, every *s* a *z*, every *t* a *d*, every *h* a *b*.

You have now met four signs that take it – は, こ, ち and か – and two of them are in the word this chapter is building.

Your turn

- *Write it:* か, then add the two ticks to make か. Say both.
- *Write it:* こ, then こ
- *Say it:* **ka** / **ga**, then **ko** / **go** — the same mouth, voice off and on

Before you move on

Does か need a new shape learned? (**No** — it is か plus two ticks.)
Source: Unicode Hiragana chart

3.5 と — two strokes, and they never meet

Write か. Then say what the two ticks did to it.

Script — the shape

と

Two strokes, and like ㇿ they stay apart:

1. a **short stroke** at the upper left, little more than a tick leaning down-right
2. a **long sweeping stroke** starting above and to the right of it, falling down and left, then curving out to the right at the bottom

The second stroke does the work. It should look like a single confident sweep, not a corner — the change of direction is a curve, not a bend.

Read **to**: a clean *t*, then the *o* of *more*, shortened. One beat.

Your turn

- *Write it:* と — the small tick, then the long sweep. Do not join them.
- *Say it:* **a, ri, ga, to** — four beats, and the word is nearly yours

Before you move on

Which stroke is longer? (The **second**, the sweep.)
Source: Unicode Hiragana chart

3.6 う — two strokes, and a vowel that stretches

Write と. Tick, then sweep, no join.

Script — the shape

う

Two strokes, the simplest pair in this chapter:

1. a **short tick** at the top, roughly horizontal 2. a **wide curve** beneath it, falling from the upper left, bellying right, and tapering away to the lower left

Read **u**: close to the *oo* of *food* but shorter, and with the lips much less rounded than an English speaker expects. Do not push them forward.

What you've built — and what this sign does after と

Something happens when う follows と, and it is the reason the written word and the spoken word look like they disagree.

Written out, ありがとう ends と + う — *to* then *u*, which reads as five beats. But nobody says *a-ri-ga-to-u*. What you hear is a long **o**:

written: a-ri-ga-to-u

>

spoken: a-ri-ga-**too**

う after an o-sound does not add a syllable. It holds the one before it for a second beat. The beat is still there — Japanese counts it, and dropping it makes the word sound clipped and wrong — but it is the same vowel continuing, not a new one.

You met this once already without being told: the katakana word コーヒー uses a long bar for the same job. Hiragana uses う.

Your turn

- *Write it:* う — the tick, then the wide curve
- *Say it:* **to**, then **too** — one beat, then two, same vowel

Before you move on

Is the extra beat optional? (**No** — Japanese counts it, and dropping it sounds clipped.)

Source: Unicode Hiragana chart

3.7 ありがとう — no new sign, and a whole word

Write あ, り and か in a row. Then add the two ticks to the last one.

Script — the assembly

Here is the word you have been saying since Chapter 1:

ありがとう

Nothing in it is new. Take it sign by sign:

- あ — *a*, the three-stroke sign with the loop
- り — *ri*, short left, long right, tapped
- が — *ga*, which is か with the dakuten
- と — *to*, tick and sweep
- う — *u*, which here holds the *o* before it for a second beat

Five signs, five beats, and you can write every one.

That is the whole point of the last five lessons. In Chapter 1 this word was a sound you copied and a romanization you leaned on. It is now something you can read off a shop sign, and — more to the point — something you could write on a note without being able to say a single sentence of Japanese.

Read it slowly, once per sign, then at speed: *a-ri-ga-to-o*.

Your turn

- *Read it:* ありがとう — name each sign before you say the word
- *Write it:* ありがとう — all five, in order, without looking above
- *Say it:* **arigatou** — five beats, the last two one long *o*

Before you move on

How many signs did you have to learn for this word? (**Five** — but one of them was free, because が is か with two ticks.)

Source: Unicode Hiragana chart

3.8 さ — two strokes, and the ticks work here too

Write ありがとう. All five signs, no help.

Script — the shape

さ

Three strokes:

1. a short **horizontal**, near the top 2. a **short curving stroke** below it, falling down and left 3. a **separate small curve** at the foot, opening left — **not joined** to the stroke above it

Watch that gap. Most printed fonts join the second and third strokes into one continuous descender, so the さ you see on a screen looks like two strokes. By hand it is three, and the break is real. The same split makes き four strokes by hand and three in print.

Read **sa**: a clean *s*, then the short *a*. One beat.

And now the bargain again — さ takes the dakuten:

さ *sa* → ざ *za*

Same mouth, voice switched on, two ticks at the upper right. That is the third sign you have got for free, and it is the second sign of ございます.

Your turn

- *Write it:* さ — horizontal, the short curve, then the detached foot curve
- *Write it:* ざ — the same, with two ticks
- *Say it:* **sa** / **za**

Before you move on

How many signs have the two ticks given you so far? (**Three** — が, ご and ざ.)

Source: Unicode Hiragana chart

3.9 ま — three strokes, and a loop you have drawn before

Write ざ, then ざ.

Script — the shape

ま

Three strokes, and the order is top-down as always:

1. an **upper horizontal**, short 2. a **lower horizontal**, a little wider, below and parallel to it 3. a **looping vertical** that crosses both, falls, and curls left at the bottom

The third stroke is the same movement you learned on あ — down through what you have written, then a small loop at the foot. If あ's loop is comfortable, this one is already yours.

Read **ma**: as in English *mother*, shortened. One beat.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ま — two horizontals, then the looping vertical through them
- *Say it:* **ma**, one beat

Before you move on

Which earlier sign uses the same looping last stroke? (あ.)

Source: Unicode Hiragana chart

3.10 す — two strokes, and a vowel you barely hear

Write ま. Two horizontals, then the loop.

Script — the shape

す

Two strokes:

1. a short **horizontal**, near the top 2. a **vertical** crossing it, falling, and finishing in a loop that closes back on itself before tailing away

The loop in す is tighter than ま's — it comes back and crosses its own line.

Read **su**: an *s*, then the *u* you met in う.

Why it's said this way

At the end of a word, and especially in ございます, that final *u* is usually **devoiced** — the mouth makes the shape, the beat is counted, but the vocal cords never switch on. What a listener hears is closer to *-mass* than *-masu*.

This is not sloppiness or fast speech. It is what standard Tokyo Japanese does, and saying a full clear *u* there is one of the most recognisable marks of a learner reading off a page.

The sign is still written. The beat is still counted. Only the voice drops out.

Your turn

- *Write it:* す — horizontal, then the vertical with its closing loop
- *Say it:* **su**, then the same with the voice off — a whispered ending

Before you move on

Is the beat dropped along with the voice? (**No** — the beat is still counted.)

Source: Unicode Hiragana chart

3.11 Practice — the whole thank-you, off the page

Write ありがとう. Five signs, no help.

Script — the second half

ございます

Five more signs, and **again nothing here is new**:

- ご — こ from Chapter 2, with the dakuten
- ざ — さ from this chapter, with the dakuten
- い — from Chapter 2
- ま — from this chapter
- す — from this chapter, its *u* devoiced

Two of the five are signs you already had, wearing two ticks.

Why it's said this way

ありがとう on its own is warm and ordinary — friends, family, a shopkeeper you know. ありがとうございます is the same thanks in polite form, and it is what you want for a stranger, a colleague, anyone serving you.

The difference is not strength. Adding ございます does not mean you are *more* grateful; it means you are being **more formal about it**. Getting that wrong in either direction is the commonest register mistake a beginner makes.

If you are unsure which to use, use the long one. Being slightly too polite in Japanese costs you nothing.

The exchange

Two voices, and every sign on the page is one you can write:

A: こんにちは

>

B: こんにちは

>

A: ありがとうございます

>

B: はい

What you've built this chapter

Eight new signs and one mark. The mark is the part worth remembering:

- **eight shapes** — ありがとうさます
- **one mark** — ` , which turned か into が, こ into ご, さ into ざ

Ten signs in ありがとうございます, and only eight of them cost you a shape. The dakuten is the first thing in this book that made the job *smaller* the further you went into it, and it keeps doing that: every *k*, *s*, *t* and *h* sign you ever learn arrives with a voiced twin already attached.

Your turn

- *Read it:* ありがとうございます — name each of the ten signs, then say it
- *Write it:* ございます — five signs, two of them with ticks
- *Say it:* **arigatou gozaimasu** — and let the final u go quiet

Before you move on

Which form would you use with a stranger — the short one or the long one? (The **long** one; being slightly too polite costs nothing.)
Source: Unicode Hiragana chart

Pronunciation & Writing

Reference

A **reference**, not a chapter. Look a sound up when a lesson names it; do not read this page first. Japanese script is taught inside words the learner can already use, one sign at a time.

Romanization on this track is Hepburn with macrons (*arigatō*, *kōhī*). It is temporary scaffolding. Where a lesson is teaching beat count, it also spells the word out mora by mora (*a-ri-ga-to-o*), because a macron hides exactly the thing being taught.

The writing system in four facts

1. **There are three systems, and they run together.** An ordinary sentence uses all three at once: **hiragana** for grammar, **kanji** for content words, **katakana** for borrowings. None of them is a stage the others replace.
2. **Hiragana and katakana are moraic twins.** One sign is one beat, normally a consonant plus a vowel already fused. The two sets cover the same beats with different shapes; katakana marks a word as coming from outside.
3. **Kanji carry meaning, not a fixed sound.** 日 is read *nichi*, *jitsu*, *hi*, *bi*, or *ka*. A lesson therefore teaches the reading a **word** uses, never “the sound of the character.”
4. **Beats are counted, not stressed.** Every mora is the same length, and length is contrastive: いえ (2 beats) is a house, いいえ (3) is “no.”

Japanese has no case, no grammatical gender, no articles, and no plural agreement — so several standing methods in this curriculum simply do not

apply here. It does have an obligatory politeness level on every predicate, which nothing else in the corpus has.

Sound ids used by the Chapter 1 lessons

- **mora** — give every written sign one equal beat; do not stress one over another. First anchor: はい *hai*.
- **pure-vowels** — five vowels, held steady, no English glide: *a, i, u, e, o*. First anchor: はい *hai*.
- **mora-length** — a long vowel is a second beat, and it changes meaning. First anchor: いいえ *ie* against いえ *ie*.
- **moraic-n** — ん is a consonant that owns a whole beat of its own. First anchor: こんにちは *konnichiwa*.
- **particle-wa** — the sign は is read *wa* when it is working as the topic particle. First anchor: こんにちは.
- **chouon** — the katakana bar — adds one more beat of the vowel before it. First anchor: コーヒー *kōhī*.
- **dakuten** — two short strokes voice a kana: *ka→ga, sa→za, ta→da, ha→ba*. First anchor: ありがとう *arigatō*.
- **long-o** — in hiragana a long *o* is normally written with う, not a bar. First anchor: ありがとう *arigatō*.

Two things this page deliberately does not do

It does not print the kana chart. A learner who wants the full grid will find it anywhere; a learner who is told to memorise it before Lesson 1 usually stops there, which is the wall HL00 exists to remove.

It does not claim a stroke count as a prerequisite. Stroke order for kana and kanji is real and taught, and it lives in Japanese script reference beside each sign, to be consulted when a hand is free.

Sources

- Wiktionary: はい, 今日は, 有難う, and コーヒー.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

ありがとう *arigatō*

thank you (plain)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

ありがとうございます *arigatō gozaimasu*

thank you (polite)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

はい *hai*

yes

Introduced in Chapter 1.

いいえ *iie*

no; not at all

Introduced in Chapter 1.

コーヒー *kōhī*

coffee

Introduced in Chapter 1.

こんにちは *konnichiwa*

hello (daytime greeting)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

日本語 *nihongo*

the Japanese language

Introduced in Chapter 1.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 1

1.1 はい — *yes, in two equal beats*

Write the Japanese word for 'yes' in hiragana.

1.2 いいえ — *no, and why the extra beat matters*

How many beats (morae) does いいえ hold?

1.3 こんにちは — *hello, and a sign that lies about its sound*

The greeting ends in the sign は. How is it pronounced there?

1.4 日本語 — *three characters, and no single sound each*

How is the character 日 read inside 日本語?

1.5 コーヒー — *the third system, and a word that really is a cousin*

What does the bar — do in コーヒー?

1.6 ありがとう — *thanks, from “this hardly ever happens”*

Which hiragana sign becomes が when the dakuten is added?

1.7 ありがとうございます — *politeness you cannot leave out*

You are thanking a shop assistant you have never met. Which form do you use?

1.8 Practice — *one daytime exchange, three scripts*

Someone has just thanked you politely. Give the modest one-word reply this chapter taught.

Chapter 2

2.1 い — *two strokes, one beat*

How many strokes does the hiragana sign for 'i' have?

2.2 は — *three strokes*

How many strokes does the hiragana sign read 'ha' have?

2.3 *Two signs, side by side — and a word appears*

How many beats (morae) does the written word for 'yes' take?

2.4 え — *two strokes, and a second word for free*

How many beats (morae) does the written word for 'no' take?

2.5 こ — *two strokes, and the greeting begins*

How many strokes does the hiragana sign read 'ko' have?

2.6 ん — *one stroke, one beat, no vowel*

Which vowel does this sign carry?

2.7 に — *three strokes, and a shape you half know*

Two signs so far share a similar left-hand vertical. Does that shared shape tell you anything about their sound or meaning?

2.8 ち — *two strokes, four roman letters, one beat*

This sign is romanised with four letters. How many beats does it take?

2.9 わ — *the sign for wa, and the trap beside it*

The daytime greeting ends in a sound like 'wa'. Is it written with the sign for wa, or the sign for ha?

2.10 *Five signs in a row — and the greeting is readable*

How many beats (morae) does the written daytime greeting take?

Chapter 3

3.1 あ — *three strokes, and the thank-you begins*

How many strokes does the hiragana sign read 'a' have?

3.2 り — *two strokes, and a tap rather than an r*

Is the Japanese r in 'ri' closer to an English r or to a single tap of the tongue?

3.3 か — *three strokes, and a shape you will reuse*

How many strokes does the hiragana sign read 'ka' have?

3.4 “ — *two ticks, and every sign you know doubles*

What do the two small marks of the dakuten do to a hiragana sign?

3.5 と — *two strokes, and they never meet*

Do the two strokes of the sign read 'to' touch each other?

3.6 う — *two strokes, and a vowel that stretches*

When u follows an o-sound in hiragana, what does it do?

3.7 **ありがとう** — *no new sign, and a whole word*

Which sign in **ありがとう** is another sign plus the dakuten, and what is underneath it?

3.8 **さ** — *two strokes, and the ticks work here too*

What does the sign read 'sa' become when the dakuten is added?

3.9 **ま** — *three strokes, and a loop you have drawn before*

How many strokes does the hiragana sign read 'ma' have?

3.10 **す** — *two strokes, and a vowel you barely hear*

At the end of gozaimasu, what happens to the final u?

3.11 *Practice — the whole thank-you, off the page*

In **ありがとうございます**, how many signs are an earlier sign plus the dakuten?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 1

1.1 はい — *yes, in two equal beats*

Answer: はい

Also accepted: hai; ha-i

1.2 いいえ — *no, and why the extra beat matters*

Answer: three

Also accepted: 3; three beats; three morae

1.3 こんにちは — *hello, and a sign that lies about its sound*

Answer: wa

Also accepted: as wa; わ; the topic particle wa

1.4 日本語 — *three characters, and no single sound each*

Answer: ni

Also accepted: as ni; に; read ni

1.5 コーヒー — *the third system, and a word that really is a cousin*

Answer: it holds the vowel for one more beat

Also accepted: lengthens the vowel; long vowel; it lengthens the previous vowel; adds a beat to the vowel

1.6 ありがとう — *thanks, from “this hardly ever happens”*

Answer: か

Also accepted: ka; か ka

1.7 ありがとうございます — *politeness you cannot leave out*

Answer: ありがとうございます

Also accepted: arigato gozaimasu; arigatou gozaimasu; arigatō gozaimasu; the polite one

1.8 Practice — *one daytime exchange, three scripts*

Answer: いいえ

Also accepted: iie; no; not at all

Chapter 2

2.1 い — *two strokes, one beat*

Answer: 2

Also accepted: two; 2 strokes; two strokes

2.2 は — *three strokes*

Answer: 3

Also accepted: three; 3 strokes; three strokes

2.3 Two signs, side by side — *and a word appears*

Answer: 2

Also accepted: two; 2 beats; two beats

2.4 え — *two strokes, and a second word for free*

Answer: 3

Also accepted: three; 3 beats; three beats

2.5 こ — *two strokes, and the greeting begins*

Answer: 2

Also accepted: two; 2 strokes; two strokes

2.6 くん — *one stroke, one beat, no vowel*

Answer: none

Also accepted: no vowel; not any; it has none; nothing

2.7 に — *three strokes, and a shape you half know*

Answer: no

Also accepted: none; it does not; nothing; no it does not

2.8 ち — *two strokes, four roman letters, one beat*

Answer: 1

Also accepted: one; one beat; 1 beat

2.9 わ — *the sign for wa, and the trap beside it*

Answer: ha

Also accepted: the ha sign; sign for ha; ha sign

2.10 Five signs in a row — *and the greeting is readable*

Answer: 5

Also accepted: five; 5 beats; five beats

Chapter 3

3.1 あ — *three strokes, and the thank-you begins*

Answer: 3

Also accepted: three; 3 strokes; three strokes

3.2 り — *two strokes, and a tap rather than an r*

Answer: a single tap

Also accepted: a tap; tap; single tap; closer to a tap

3.3 か — *three strokes, and a shape you will reuse*

Answer: 3

Also accepted: three; 3 strokes; three strokes

3.4 っ — *two ticks, and every sign you know doubles*

Answer: they voice the consonant

Also accepted: voice it; voices the consonant; make it voiced; turn k into g; they make the consonant voiced

3.5 と — *two strokes, and they never meet*

Answer: no

Also accepted: they do not touch; no, they stay apart; separate; no they are separate

3.6 う — *two strokes, and a vowel that stretches*

Answer: it lengthens the o

Also accepted: makes the o long; holds the o for another beat; lengthens the vowel; it makes it a long o

3.7 ありがとう — *no new sign, and a whole word*

Answer: ga, which is ka

Also accepted: が, from か; ga from ka; the third sign, ka; が is か plus the marks; ka

3.8 さ — *two strokes, and the ticks work here too*

Answer: za

Also accepted: ざ; it becomes za

3.9 ま — *three strokes, and a loop you have drawn before*

Answer: 3

Also accepted: three; 3 strokes; three strokes

3.10 す — *two strokes, and a vowel you barely hear*

Answer: it is devoiced

Also accepted: it goes quiet; devoiced; you barely hear it; the voice drops out; it is almost silent

3.11 Practice — *the whole thank-you, off the page*

Answer: 3

Also accepted: three; 3 signs; three signs; ga za and go; が ご ざ

Sources for this starter edition

Word histories follow Wiktionary's Japanese entries for はい, 今日は, 有難う, and コーヒー. The companion Markdown lessons carry the per-lesson citations and are the canonical short-practice source for this edition; the chapter that follows is generated from them, so the two cannot drift apart.

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

C

coffee コーヒー (kōhī)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

E

Eight Signs, and Three Words You Can Read

chapter topic; Chapter 2, p. 11

Eight Signs, One Mark, and the Longest Word You Know

chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 21

F

Five signs in a row — and the greeting is readable

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11

H

hello (daytime greeting) こんにちは (konnichiwa)

explicit focus: script, grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

N

no; not at all いいえ (iie)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

T

thank you (plain) ありがとう (arigatō)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

thank you (polite) ありがとうございます (arigatō gozaimasu)

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the Japanese language 日本語 (nihongo)

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Three Writing Systems in One Doorway

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Two signs, side by side — and a word appears

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11

“ — two ticks, and every sign you know doubles

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 21

Y

yes はい (hai)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

Other

あ — three strokes, and the thank-you begins

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 21

ありがとう — no new sign, and a whole word

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 21

い — two strokes, one beat

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う — two strokes, and a vowel that stretches

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 21

え — two strokes, and a second word for free

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11

か — three strokes, and a shape you will reuse

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 21

こ — two strokes, and the greeting begins

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11

さ — two strokes, and the ticks work here too

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 21

す — two strokes, and a vowel you barely hear

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, usage and culture; Chapter 3, p. 21

ち — two strokes, four roman letters, one beat

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11

と — **two strokes, and they never meet**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 21

に — **three strokes, and a shape you half know**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11

は — **three strokes**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11

ま — **three strokes, and a loop you have drawn before**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 21

り — **two strokes, and a tap rather than an r**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 3, p. 21

わ — **the sign for *wa*, and the trap beside it**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11

ん — **one stroke, one beat, no vowel**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 2, p. 11